

So you're thinking about construction management

The short version — written for you, not about you.

Everything that matters, none of the bits written for your parents.

Or maybe you aren't — because almost nobody mentions this one.

We scored twenty-seven careers on how exposed they are to AI. A site superintendent came out at **3.3 out of 10**.

That's better than **licensed engineering (4.0)**. Better than **architecture (5.0)**. Better than a business degree (7.6).

Median pay is around \$106,980, projected growth is 9% — "much faster than average" per the government's own classification — and there are roughly 46,800 openings a year.

And your school careers office probably hasn't said a word about it.

The 60-second version

- Site-based construction management scores better than engineering, architecture or business.
 - **No graduate degree. No licence exam in most places.** Progression runs on competence.
 - The thing protecting it is unusual: **there are multiple ways in**, and they compete with each other.
 - The office roles score 7.4. The site roles score 3.3. That's a 4.1-point gap on the same project.
 - And the AI data centre buildout is driving demand — \$100 billion of it in 2026 alone.
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Why it's protected

You have to physically be there. Walking the site, checking the work, seeing what's actually happening rather than what's in the report. Construction sites are among the *hardest* environments for automation — nothing is where the drawing says it is.

Every site is genuinely new. Different ground, different team, different problems, arriving without warning.

And you're accountable when someone gets hurt. Safety responsibility attaches to a named person, and that's not a technical problem to solve.

The thing that actually makes this career resilient

Here's the argument, and it applies well beyond construction.

Most careers have **one** way in. A law degree. A medical degree. A CS degree into a graduate scheme. When that route narrows — which is what's happening across this whole index — the whole profession narrows with it.

Construction management has at least four.

- A construction management degree
- Coming up through a trade and moving into supervision — completely normal here, not a second-class route
- Engineering graduates crossing over
- Estimators and office staff moving to site

And they compete with each other. No single gatekeeper controls entry.

Plus the entry work itself is physical — an assistant superintendent learns by walking the site and chasing subcontractors, which can't be automated the way a junior analyst's spreadsheets can.

So when you're weighing any career, ask: how many doors are there? One door is fragile. Four is resilient even when one of them narrows.

The scores

ROLE	SCORE
Site superintendent	3.3
Construction project manager	4.2
Estimator / quantity surveyor	6.3
Scheduler / planner	7.0
Preconstruction / document coordination	7.4

A 4.1-point gap on the same project. The person in the mud and the person managing the document set work on the same building, and one of them is doing work a machine handles

well.

Which matters practically, because the office jobs are the ones that look like promotions. Worth knowing that before someone offers you one.

Where the demand actually is

The industry is genuinely short of people:

- **92% of contractors** report difficulty filling open positions (AGC survey)
- **80%** specifically struggle with salaried roles
- **45%** say shortages are directly causing project delays
- Around **349,000 net new workers** needed in 2026, and 456,000 in 2027

And the AI buildout is a direct driver. Reporting suggests tech companies could put upwards of \$100 billion into US data centre construction in 2026 alone, on top of CHIPS Act megaprojects, healthcare and defence work.

Same pattern as electricians: a career protected from AI that's simultaneously being pulled by it.

One honest thing about that

We'd rather tell you than let the shortage numbers oversell it.

The construction hiring rate hit 3.3% in February 2026 — the lowest on record since the government started measuring it in 2000.

That sits oddly next to "92% of contractors can't fill positions." Both are true.

What's happening: construction spending growth has slowed, so firms are starting fewer projects and hiring cautiously — while still being unable to find experienced people for the work they do have.

It's a shortage of qualified people in a market that's hiring carefully. Not the same as a boom.

The skills shortage is demographic and will outlast the cycle. But if you graduate during a slow period, it'll feel tighter than the headlines suggest.

What we won't soften

Construction is cyclical. It rises and falls with credit conditions and public spending in a way nursing and teaching don't.

The hours are long and the weather doesn't care. A superintendent absorbs pressure from the client, the designer, the subcontractors, the inspectors and their own firm — often simultaneously.

Responsibility arrives early and it's real. Safety accountability isn't abstract.

And the median isn't the headline. Most construction managers aren't on \$170,000. The middle of the market is closer to \$105,000 — the average gets pulled up by big metros and complex infrastructure work.

Where the money actually is

Worth knowing early, because these are choices rather than luck:

- **BIM and platform fluency: +10–15% pay.** That's the single best skill investment here.
 - **Sector matters a lot:** heavy civil \$121,060, commercial \$120,010, specialty trade \$102,140, residential \$91,150
 - **Data centres, healthcare and industrial** carry premiums for complexity
 - Certifications (CCM, PMP, OSHA) typically add \$5,000–\$15,000
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Does this actually sound like you?

It suits people who:

- Are **practical and organised** in equal measure — that specific combination is the job
- Are comfortable being **responsible for other people's safety**
- Can **get people who disagree to agree** — most of the job, honestly
- Would rather be **moving than at a desk**
- **Want the thing to exist afterwards**

Harder if you need predictable indoor hours, find conflict draining, want creative freedom (architecture is closer to that), or need stability through an economic cycle.

What actually matters when picking a course

- **How much of the placement is actually on site, not in an office?**
- **Named contractor relationships** and real conversion rates
- **BIM taught properly**, as understanding rather than software training
- **What job titles do graduates have at six months** — site or office? That's a 4.1-point difference.

Two things worth doing

Get on a site. Labouring, work experience, a summer with a contractor. **Nothing else builds the ability to read a site** — and that's the thing separating a good superintendent from a competent administrator.

Then talk to both a site superintendent and a preconstruction manager and ask each what their day looks like. The contrast between those two answers is basically this whole document.

One last thing

If you like building things and someone has told you the options are "a trade" or "architecture" — **this is the third one.**

It pays more than both at the median. It scores better than both. You don't need a graduate degree or a licence exam. And you can get there from a trade, from a degree, or sideways from engineering.

It's the most overlooked good option we found, and the reason is mostly that it doesn't sound impressive at a dinner party.

If you want to go further — three things worth twenty minutes

- **Construction Managers — Occupational Outlook Handbook** — the government's own data on pay, growth and openings, including the sector-by-sector breakdown.

- AGC construction data — the industry's own workforce survey. Where the 92% figure comes from.
 - Construction management career opportunities — on where demand is concentrated, including the data centre story.
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There's a longer version behind this — full scores by role, how they were worked out, the honest downsides, what to ask a program, and where we might be wrong. Your parents have it.